

Meow-Meow – Tim Scallon

Billy collects cats. Billy keeps the cats in the garage with the glassware as long as they promise to be good cats and not knock the glassware over. Knocking over the glassware would be bad. Bad for health, bad for business. Billy needs to stop leaving the dregs of his morning coffee to cool and sit by the glassware. The cats like grape juice. Billy left out grape juice once and now the cats think the coffee is grape juice and dab at it with their paws. The cats lick their paws and drink the coffee and stay up and run around and knock over the glassware. The glassware contains powders and liquids. The powders are red and white and dark purple. The liquids are clear like water but they are not water and they burn like hell when they knock over.

Billy has been crushing the strike pads from matchboxes all day. Not because it's fun, but for the red phosphorus because Billy can't buy the red phosphorus because Billy is a convicted felon. The matches came from CVS and CVS sells pure iodine too and that is also crucial for manufacturing crank. CVS also sells Sudafed and Billy knows the clerk and the clerk buys crank from Billy most weeks so he lets Billy buy as much Sudafed as he damn well asks to buy. Billy is federally banned from purchasing Sudafed and pure iodine and his name and face are in a database that shows his convictions but the clerk and Billy have a mutual understanding. Billy also uses the iodine to treat his skin condition. The skin condition is from making crank all day.

The crank buys cat food. Wet cat food, dry cat food, tinned and bagged. The crank is just bagged. A big bag of cat food costs the same price as a hit of crank and Billy had more cat food than he knew what to do with but then he got more cats. Maybe when he sells more crank or buys less cat food Billy can think of buying something for himself besides personal crank. Billy has been making crank all day for seven years. He has been using crank all day for nearly as long because everyone just wants to get high on their own supply. He heard that in a song once.

Billy lives in a house that is the same size as his garage. Billy has five cats and they piss and spray and stink the garage up. The smell of cat piss is the only thing that Billy believes will keep the DEA and the FBI and the ABCDEFG from discovering his cookery, and so Billy's cats are free to piss anywhere and everywhere in the garage. Once the cats pissed in the glassware and Billy's crank got too much cat piss in it and it tasted more like cat piss than Billy's crank usually did and the CVS clerk complained. The CVS clerk isn't usually picky about Billy's crank and crank tastes like cat piss anyway so it was a big deal and Billy has to keep the cats off the glassware now. It is difficult to keep one cat off the glassware and more so to keep five off.

Name: *Crystal* **Age:** *4 yrs* **Pre-Existing Conditions:** *W epistasis deafness*

The white deaf cat is pawing at Billy's coffee and drips are gathering on the table and Billy is yelling at her to stop but the *W* gene made her white and it made her deaf. Crystal does not have white privilege. The *W* gene broke the melanocytes and that broke her inner ears but gave her pretty blue eyes that do work. She was Billy's first cat of five cats and he named her Crystal because of her pretty blue eyes but also because Crystal is what Billy's customers sometimes call the crank. Crystal the white deaf cat was a wandering stray and Billy saw her wandering so he left grape juice on the drive spit for her by the oil stains. The oil stains are from cars and the cars come and go nonstop but Billy doesn't have a car. Crystal doesn't come when Billy calls and doesn't even look. Billy hasn't yet figured out that Crystal is and always has been deaf. He assumes her unresponsive demeanor is the result of a bad attitude and continues trying to break down this imaginary emotional wall. This of course always fails and Billy gets frustrated and takes big gulps of the coffee he makes every morning. The coffee isn't very good on its own so Billy puts crank in the coffee. Crystal never hears the coffee brewing or pouring or the mug slamming on the table on the garage but she smells it and never hears Billy yelling.

Billy doesn't like to yell at Crystal because Crystal was the first cat and Billy was lonely but Crystal was a friend who didn't leave when the crank ran out. Crystal doesn't know either way but she loves Billy because he gave her grape juice two years ago and still sometimes gives her grape juice but sometimes gives her icky juice that makes her run around and knock over the glassware. Crystal didn't hear four months ago when the fat man with the handlebar mustache and the shiny head pulled out a .32 caliber revolver and told Billy gimme all the crank you got or this cat is fuckin' dead and you too. Crystal didn't hear Billy sobbing when the fat man left with the crank and Billy's dignity and security but she let him hold and hug her anyway. Crystal doesn't mind the reek of the crank bulb and doesn't hear Billy lighting it or babbling about nothing to her once he's wasted so she stays on his lap. Billy got a shotgun the next day.

The regular customers don't see much of the cats but the CVS clerk likes cats and he has seen them sometimes during his weekly crank pickup. He thinks Crystal is retarded because she doesn't notice the garage door or the glassware or anything and can't take cues from anybody and her meows are weird. Billy defends Crystal and says she's just too smart to waste her time talking to stupid people. The CVS clerk says whatever just hit me when there's more crank. There will be more crank in a few hours if Crystal the deaf white cat stops drinking the coffee and stepping over Billy's face while he crushes the strike pads. The strike pads are flammable and Billy keeps the gas burners on the left side of the tabletop turned off when not in use. Crystal likes to bat at the knobs. The other cats usually leave her alone because she never hears them.

Name: *Tina* **Age:** *5 yrs* **Pre-Existing Conditions:** *Klinefelter Syndrome*

Billy has been trying to breed his cats and get more cats. His favorite is the calicolike one with the bright grey eyes and when he hits the crank bulb they almost look fuchsia in the light. The orange and white and brown melt together like chocolate and caramel and Billy wants more

cats like this. Tina is named Tina because he doesn't have a penis and Billy thought he was a girl and besides all calicolikes are girls or so he heard. Tina is what the hippies call intersex and Tina has XXY sex chromosomes and thus resembles a boy and a girl. Tina is as close to being a boy as a calicolike can be but is also as close to being a girl. Billy found out that Tina couldn't have babies either way because his sperm are twisted and his eggs are shriveled. Billy does not have a microscope or a high school education or access to a local veterinarian but he knows what sperm and eggs are and knows that he tried to get Tina to breed with all four of his sibling cats without results. Tina *does* have a penis but he is certainly no Priapus and seems largely uninterested in sex even though he and his sibling cats were never fixed. Tina is also slang for crank.

Billy is interested in sex and he also has a penis but he has no female customers ever since Jolene got booked for possession. Jolene is still serving time at County. Billy has no friends that are people and thus no girlfriends these days. His girlfriends used to just be the female customers like Jolene but he knew they only pretended to like him because he makes good crank that only tastes a little bit like cat piss but gets you fucked up. It didn't matter that they only pretended when they were all wasted on crank because Billy could pretend too when they called him baby or sweetie that they meant it and that they loved him and not just the crank. Sometimes when the crank wears off Billy just sits and thinks about how he misses a woman's touch, physically, metaphorically. Billy thinks he wants a normal family and a normal life someday but today is not someday it is today. Today is a day for making crank all day.

Jolene was blonde and she was pretty and she was only twenty-two the first time she tried crank. She loved it because it made her feel smarter and prettier and powerful like a God. Or a Goddess. Jolene was saving money for college but then she was saving money for crank and then she was turning tricks for crank because the money ran out and then the money stopped saving.

Billy didn't always fuck her sometimes he just wanted to hang out and smoke crank and talk. Once after Billy got home from a weekend in jail Jolene came over and nobody had crank but Jolene found a rock in the rug by the piss filled garage couch and they smoked the carpet crank. The carpet crank wasn't carpet crank. It was a piece of cat litter and it tasted like shit and they laughed and laughed because Billy doesn't even use cat litter, just lets 'em piss. Jolene never really minded the cat piss because she liked the cats especially the pretty grey-eyed calicolike shemale barn cat and she liked Billy and also his crank.

Name: *Geep* **Age:** *2 yrs* **Pre-Existing Conditions:** *Diprosopus*

Billy has been crushing Sudafed all day. The Sudafed is a white pill and Billy pops the blister packs and crushes the white pills into a white powder and the powder tastes bad and dries up runny noses. Billy has a runny nose because he is allergic to cats, but Billy is generally too wasted to notice his allergies. Billy has a runny nose because he crushes every single little white pill to make crank and doesn't use any for himself. The pills of Sudafed have a groove on one side and tiny numbers on the other side before they get crushed. Two faces.

A lot of people are two-faced like the Sudafed Billy gets from the CVS clerk. None of them will show it willingly though. Billy likes Geep because he will show it always and in fact has no choice. Geep has two faces. Two mouths and three eyes. Geep is a triclops. Geep is a statistical miracle of Sonic Hedgehog and Geep is lucky to be alive. Sonic Hedgehog is the gene that gave Geep two faces but Billy only knows the game Sonic the Hedgehog for Sega. Geep is two-faced but both faces are right there facing opposite directions where Billy can see them so there is no deception afoot. Billy respects Geep for his honesty. Jolene was two-faced just like the rest of Billy's customers and started buying Meow-Meow when she couldn't afford crank

every day. The gas stations and the liquor stores and the tobacco shops are selling Meow-Meow and it's legal and it's cheaper than crank. They call it bath salts and plant food and it can't be smoked but it can be snorted. Not for human consumption. The humans take Meow-Meow and are inhuman and they tweak like it's crank or better. Billy would rather tweak off his DIY crank. Geep never tweaks ever but in all fairness Geep is probably drain damaged and misses most of what's around him but he does play with Yaba when Billy is gone. Geep chirps in an ascending pitch like a prehistoric chicken. Billy finds this amusing and lets him sip coffee as long as he promises to be a good cat and not knock over the glassware.

Billy knocked over the glassware himself just once when Jolene got arrested and she called him wasted from the jail on Meow-Meow begging for a bailout even though she hadn't called him in weeks and Billy was about to say yes when Jolene kept talking. Jolene was rambling and sounded like her teeth were chattering and holding cells are cold but not that cold. She said I'm here because of your crank and you ruined my life and I told the cops and fuck you. Billy hung up and knocked over the glassware and some of it cracked and some of it shattered. The phone rang again the next day and Billy thought it was Jolene and didn't answer and then it rang again and it was the cops. The cops said Jolene blamed him for giving her meth but there was no evidence of meth in her piss and he isn't in trouble for anything but he should know he's on their radar. Billy was wasted and didn't know it was a figure of speech and cops don't use radar to bug houses and spent the next hour putting tinfoil on the inside of the garage door.

Geep is a black cat but he is far from unlucky and only has one throat so he doesn't get deadly lung infections like the other two-faced cats. Billy trusts Geep and knows Geep can see in all directions because he is a triclops so he has to be good so Geep will trust him back. Nobody

at the shelter wanted Geep because he is two-faced like everybody else but won't hide it. Billy always keeps his word to Geep and doing that reminds him to keep his word to other people.

Name: *Yaba* **Age:** *4 yrs* **Pre-Existing Conditions:** *Strabismus, Poor Nightvision*

We are Siamese if you please; we are Siamese if you don't please. Billy saw *Lady and the Tramp* when he was seven and the dogs didn't do much for him because Billy is not a dog person but he loved the Siamese cats in the movie because they acted naughty like him and knocked things over just for fun and still knew how to stay out of trouble. Billy wanted a Siamese cat but his parents were allergic to cats and didn't much care for cats anyway and so they settled for a yippy little stupid puppy that sat and licked its own butt and pissed on the floor.

Now Billy has a Siamese cat and his name is Yaba and he knocks everything over but only at night because Siamese cats are nightblind like humans. Billy doesn't know this and thinks Yaba is actually just blind because his eyes are always crossed because they're wired to his brain backwards. Yaba is not a former resident of Siam and was born outside Indianapolis. Yaba likes to be held and carried and babied and allows Billy to believe he is totally sightless to maximize the cuddles. Billy can't hold and carry and baby Yaba for too long at a time because he has a skin condition and Yaba's bristly hairs make it much itchier and dry. The iodine is for the skin condition and also more importantly for the nucleophilic substitution of a hydroxyl group on the Sudafed. Billy dissolves some of the purple powder in water and dabs it on his arms and legs and neck while he works. Billy gets purple if he's been working for a long stretch and Yaba rubs on his legs for attention and turns purple too. His eyes are not as bad as they look and the other cats enjoy Yaba because he is not a threat to the stability of the garage hierarchy. Billy

enjoys Yaba because his eyes are goofy and Billy has always had a bit of a lazy left eye and so he can relate though Yaba can probably still see better than him.

Billy was always a troublemaker and a rebel but was not always a fiend for the crank. But growing up is hard and probably harder with no money in the family and nothing to do in or around a podunk town except get drunk and high and Billy was a smart guy who made some poor decisions. Booze was okay but it made you tired and lazy and stupid but crank made Billy alert and smart and driven and creative. When he hit the crank bulb he could run faster and think harder and fuck longer and just be a God. Maybe he could have been his own God without the crank but the crank worked just fine. Even if it was a bad decision, getting Yaba was a good one.

Siam used to be in the golden triangle and people there made heroin poppies but now they make and take crank to work and stay awake. They call it yaba which means crazy medicine and the yaba comes in little pills the workers vaporize on tinfoil. Billy heard this on TV and has been trying to reach out to Asian contacts and get a corner on the foreign market. Billy has no Asian contacts of course and has been trying to sell crank to the Chinese food deliverymen but they get angry because they don't want his crank and because he smells like cat piss and is stained purple. Yaba tries to eat the Chinese food but Billy won't share so Yaba drinks the crank coffee and stays up all night with Geep knocking over the glassware.

Name: *Shabu* **Age:** 1 yr **Pre-Existing Conditions:** *Other-GMO*

Shabu is a special cat. All Billy's cats are special but Shabu is special-special. Another immigrant but this time from South Korea. Billy thinks she is from Japan because he does not own a map or books and she has an Asian letter 스물 tattooed in her belly in green but now her name is in Japanese so too late. Shabu is an experiment in humans playing God in a lab.

Billy had a Strange Customer three weeks back who was Asian and looked like a fancy scientist because he was dressed well in a white coat but he didn't have money just a cat. I hear you like strange cats he said; maybe we can work out a trade he said. Billy said she looks like a normal grey tabby to me what's her deal? The Strange Customer said she is Number 20 and is a cat from the future. Billy said that's bullshit I'm no idiot give me cash or get out of here. The Strange Customer pulled out a wand from his coat and Billy was wasted on crank so he was about to freak and grab the shotgun that he sawed down illegally. The strange customer said turn off the light you won't be disappointed. Billy was paranoid but also curious and turned off the light. The wand flickered and turned purple and the future cat turned green and Billy had no further questions except holy shit what the hell. The strange customer said a lot of smart things like DNA and jellyfish protein and ultraviolet and Billy was tuning it out but then the Strange Customer said keep her I only need a half-gram. Sold.

A cat from the future. Or rather a cat from the present that represents the cats of the future. The word Billy is looking for is transgenic and Shabu the cat is what the hippies call a GMO and she is not labeled. She is a cat with itty-bitty jellyfish DNA pieces in her skin and they make her glow in the dark if she's under a black light. Billy has decided to set aside enough cash for some black light bulbs from the Halloween store so Shabu can always be pretty and green. It's the first nonessential item he's planned to buy himself in ages and he ponders what else he could buy if he saved some more money from the crank he makes and sells all day. Certainly more of these green cats but also better things for himself. Like a TV with real channels and even a computer with Internet or a car even if it's just a junker. Billy could maybe post bail for Jolene and see her if she would want to see him. Surely she would. After all even though Billy ignored her calls to apologize she still apologized so maybe there was a chance things could work out.

The Strange Customer let Billy keep the wand with the GMO cat and he's waving it absentmindedly while he packs the crank bulb and sets out the prepared ingredients to finish his day's work. Billy starts every day at eight in the morning and the crank cooking gets done about eight at night and the shift would probably not be worth it except for all of the free crank all day. Shabu is shining like an irradiated little demon but Billy could swear he's smiling a little cat smile because the cooking is about to finally start. If Billy is happy his cats are happy. A hit of the harsh smoke makes Billy wake up a bit and focus more and feel motivated to work on finishing the crank so he puts the crank bulb down for now. The crank is Billy's livelihood and his future enchained and his only ticket away from the crank is more crank. He would set aside some more money and someday he would have enough to get some help and get a normal life with a wife that was not Jolene and children that were not cats. Billy wonders if Shabu can get pregnant and if she did would her babies all glow or just some of them. Yaba would be a good dad for those kittens if he didn't have those crossed eyes. Billy does understand heritability but can't decide from looking in his grimy cracked mirror if his children are worth having.

Every night a repeat. The Sudafed mixes with the iodine and water and makes hydroiodic acid and the acid reacts with the red phosphorus and phosphine gas is produced. The phosphine gas must be vented. Not venting the phosphine gas would be bad. Bad for health, bad for business. The burning liquid is concentrated HCl and it is corrosive and it will replace the iodine and form a hydrochloride salt with the crank molecule. Billy doesn't know the technical terms because he never took high school chemistry because he dropped out of high school but it is all the same in layman's terms minus the how it works lesson. Billy takes another hit from the bulb.

The heating element embraces the roundbottom flask with iodine and Sudafed in a 1.3/1 ratio. Billy isn't good at math but he learned the metric system from drugs and he has a scale that reads to the thousandths place and a calculator and that's the only math he needs to succeed. The powders melt into the water and they froth and turn a sanguineous dark red brown and that is called a chemical change. Some of the water turns to steam from the heat and that is called a physical change. Billy tips the crushed strike pads down a funnel into the red brown and clips on the reflux condenser. The crushed strike pads contain the red phosphorus but also glass shards for abrasion but those stay in the flask bottom for easy cleaning. Everything goes up in thick white smoke and the inside of the condenser is growing microscopic crank crystal filaments. This is the most dangerous part of the procedure and now Crystal the deaf white cat is mewing because it's past dinnertime and no food is to be found in the trough. Also the other four cats who can hear have joined in to announce their grievances. Billy was lost in thought today and forgot to feed the cats who had seemed to content to steal his crank coffee and try to knock over the glassware. Pyrex is a durable but expensive brand of borosilicate glass and will still break from too much stress or knocking over and those cats had best be careful.

Billy is dumping food in the trough and he has forgotten to vent the phosphine gas. The phosphine gas is hot and it is corrosive and deadly poisonous and it is under increasing pressure inside the glassware and the phosphine must be vented. Billy is too busy shooing five curious cats away from the dregs of his morning coffee and mixing the wet food in with the dry food to make a catsserole and doesn't notice the spidering cracks appearing across the reflux condenser. The cracks are widening and they are leaking and they burst and the release of energy heats up the phosphine gas. Phosphine gas is flammable and it requires a chemical hazard suit and a respirator. Billy cannot afford a chemical hazard suit and a respirator and spent his last surplus

on pyrex to replace the pieces he broke when he knocked the glassware over. The surplus before that was spent on pyrex to replace the 2-Liter Coke bottles that leached plastic and were scary thin and had to be vented one by one. Billy has burns to show for this primitive technology and they don't help his skin condition. He arrives at his table too late to prevent his fate.

As the flames fan outward Billy is speeding so hard that the conflagration seems to expand in slow motion. A thousand points of light culminate in the epicenter of the flask and the circular glassware appears to hatch like a transparent egg. A shockwave arrives first and Billy's brain slams against the braincase, killing him painlessly and instantly. A fireball follows closely behind and incinerates Billy's face and torso like the hippies do to the straw figure at Burning Man. There is no time for reflection, for Billy's too-short life to flash before his eyes, the love and the hatred and the joy and the misery, and it is gone just like that without a trace.

Five cats turn from their trough to witness a wall of searing Hadal tempest before it envelopes them. Fur goes up in sparks and blaze like pine needles and the longhair cats are especially unfortunate here. Whiskers wither away to cinders in midair and the proud animals are bald in seconds and the yelping will not cease as their skin catches fire and the panic sets in. The walls are on fire and the floor is on fire and the wood is old and untreated and burns without resistance. The cats yowl and howl and dance and toss themselves and stop and drop and roll and continue to burn alive with Billy who is dead.

The fire department arrives four minutes after Billy's next-door neighbor Mrs. Grundelson calls 911 and they spray hundreds of gallons of water which tear down the old walls even worse and when it's all just smoldering and black and wet the garage is gone and so is half of Billy's tiny house. The fire department can afford chemical hazard suits and respirators and they say they've seen this type of setup plenty times so they come back with them and they pick

through the rubbish to find the dead, the survivors, and the identification to bring closure to the case. Mrs. Grundelson assures them he was a nice quiet boy who had lots of friends but never bothered anyone and even sometimes offered to help wash her windows one night which struck her as odd but you know young people and their youthful energy. The dental records will have to suffice because there is no face left to identify Billy, but police have the address and name and Billy's file pulled up and if he were alive he would be in some serious hot water because they've figured out the entire operation and this isn't Billy's first crime involving methamphetamine.

Mrs. Grundelson stands by the ruins of Billy's garage, plugging her nose to mask the overwhelming odor of burning cat piss. She is watching the firefighters lift Billy's remains onto a stretcher and also the remains of four charred somethings – dogs maybe? – onto another stretcher. She thinks she just might start crying at the sight of this horrible tragedy because Mrs. Grundelson is no stranger to death and there is too much death. Her husband died two years ago from a miserable and drawn-out losing battle with prostate cancer, and their only daughter five years before in a car accident. A single tear rolls down her cheek, but its dramatic descent is cut short by a meow. Mrs. Grundelson looks down to see a singed but apparently healthy grey tabby nuzzling at her ankles and shoes. She plops over onto the widow's feet and Mrs. Grundelson can see a green marking on the cat's freshly-balded belly. She had a cat years ago and it was spayed and her eyes aren't what they used to be so she thinks the marking is an S for spayed. At least he took good care of his cats, she thinks. The only survivor, the only cat with a future, Shabu is not spayed but is affectionate and continues to rub up on Mrs. Grundelson's wrinkled calf muscles until she picks the cat up and brings her inside for some milk. Shabu laps up the milk and can't help but feel ungrateful. She wishes Mrs. Grundelson had brought her grape juice. Or better yet, coffee.